



Scripting Mail with **SHELL AND PERL**

This is a tutorial aimed at systems and middleware administrators who are new to mailing techniques but know how to use VI, VIM or any other editor. This article will also interest experts and others interested in an easier way of mailing by using a basic system and without having to install extra packages or modules.

Shell and Perl have both been used for varying purposes in the field of systems administration. However, one cannot completely replace the other. So let's look at how to send emails using Shell and Perl on UNIX/GNU Linux platforms. This is very useful while automating alerting or monitoring systems. If you know emailing in Shell, you will find it very easy to translate it in Perl. Both have almost the same lines of code in this article. What we achieve here using Shell and Perl should be equally possible with Ruby, Python or any scripting language that can make use of the existing mailing facilities in UNIX/GNU Linux.

For Perl, we will not use any mailing modules, though that is the most preferred method. This is just to make users aware that Perl can work well even without modules.

Prerequisites

Prior to exploring Shell and Perl, let's just go through the following checklist:

- i) For UNIX or GNU Linux systems, you need Fedora or Ubuntu. I am using Fedora for our examples. So my install pattern will prefer *yum* to *dpkg/apt*.
- ii) You need the Internet to reach the software repository to install packages. Though I said we wouldn't be installing packages, this is just for our test environment. We cannot practice on a production environment, so it is necessary that we have a small server environment installed to see the mailing in action.
- iii) Regarding the mail server, most companies that have Red Hat or Fedora Linux should have Sendmail configured, by default. Some might even have Postfix but the *sendmail* command is very common. The local *sendmail* command will take care of passing the mail onto the local MTA or mail transfer agent (either *sendmail* or *postfix*).
 - a. To keep things really simple, I am using:
 - Sendmail as an MTA
 - Local UNIX services as an MDA (mail delivery agent)
 - The local *mbox* as the mail delivery location
 - The *mail* command as mail client
 - System users for basic authentication and sending/receiving mail
 - b. You need to install Sendmail, as follows: